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Vacation 2.0

Learn how you can use online resources to plan your vacation

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It's that time of the year when invariably everyone catches the travel bug and decides to pack their bags and head out. But before launching off on a Lonely Planet fantasy, understand that as with all things these days, there is the old way of doing things and then there is the tech way. Sure you can call up any of the tour operators and opt for a standard package, but remember that people are increasingly becoming quite comfortable with doing their own online research for planning their vacations, and effectively cutting out the expensive middle man. Here we show you how you can plan your own vacation 2.0.

There are a multitude of online resources that can help you find all the information you need. Apart from your regular ticketing and booking facilities, you can get access to information on various destinations, deals, reviews, local curiosities and a host of other things that would've ordinarily escaped your radar. There are resources that alert travellers to peculiarities that might transform into one of those major vacation blunders. The internet, of course, is a vast jungle of information, so where do you start? Let's go step-by-step and see how it can help you along every step of the way.

With the recession around, prices have gone through the floor. Hotel occupancies

are down 30 per cent compared to last year, while prices for air travel and accommodation have been slashed by similar amounts. Everything is cheap and traveller friendly, so you can finally go to all those places you've always wanted to visit.

Part 1: Planning your itinerary

Apart from the trip itself, this can be the most fun part of your holiday! Whether you browse the web site of the bird sanctuary you've always wanted to visit, download podcasts or watch videos of tours of ancient cities, the internet makes travel so much more enjoyable. If it's a trip with several people - friends or family - you can involve everyone at this stage by sharing links to travelogues and interesting pictures. Planning your itinerary can be done beautifully on the web. A good way is to browse some of the best travel web sites so that you can zero in on a suitable trip. The idea here is to come up with a package

of your own. A package would involve the best places to see, sights and specialties to visit and things to do. Once you have chalked this out successfully, the next step involves figuring out the logistics of transportation and accommodation.

Tourism Boards

Web sites of tourism boards of states within India or countries abroad are a good place to start. You might remember the Incredible India promotional campaign by the Ministry of Tourism or the Madhya Pradesh and Kerala tourism campaigns. Many Indian states have very interesting and comprehensive government promoted tourism web sites. They showcase the various attractions found in that state and in many cases allow for booking accommodation in state-run and private facilities. For instance, keralatourism.org, which is perhaps the most elaborate of all state tourism web sites, is very comprehensive incorporating vital information such as calendar updates for local events and other facts and figures. Another good state tourism web site is rajasthantourism.gov.in which allows you to book hotels run by the state department. A simple search online will give you third-party web sites where all the state tourism board web sites are listed. Internationally, you have web sites such as visitsingapore.com which has a micro-site for India. While browsing these web sites be sure to look for special events. For instance, there could be the carnival or Goa fest happening or a concert of your favourite band coinciding with your trip to Bangkok.

Information sites

These information web sites will plant the seed of a travel idea in your mind. What you can expect to find on these websites is a large number of travelogues and custom packages. The web sites range from regular travel web sites to country specific ones and even ones for those who want to go down the road less travelled. What you can do is get inspiration from these sources and plan a customised package for yourself. This gives you all the information and the freedom of tweaking your itinerary to your convenience. Here's a small selection:

Infohub.com: a speciality travel guide web site with a lot of content. It describes itself as "the ultimate source for out-of-the-ordinary and inspiring travel ideas" and going by how extensive the information is we tend to agree. The web site has travel stories plus you can browse both by country or popular vacations, such as eco-tourism, biking tours, photography and videography, scuba diving or sports. The quick vacation search helps you narrow in on options quickly or you have the option of searching for keywords. The web site is also a great source for finding professionally managed tours.

